

and is configurable. A really interesting initiative with the developer community, where we would love to get some help with, is porting MIUI to all of the local devices. If someone with a Micromax or a Karbonn device wants to run MIUI on it, let them do it. So, we would like the help of the developer community for things like that.

We do have some developers in the country porting our builds on different devices. So, that's something we would love the developer community to help us with.

Q What would be the size of the engineering team and by when can we expect that team to come up?

We will start hiring people pretty much right away. As for the size, I don't know yet. I suspect that we would only be limited by our ability to hire quickly, as we need a really high count of engineers. The Bengaluru tech talent scene is incredibly competitive, and there is a shortage of talented people. So we will be working hard to recruit as fast as we can but I don't think we will be limited by any particular quota or budget—it's how quickly we can take this up.

Q What kind of developers are you looking to hire in India?

Mainly, Android developers. We are looking to hire people with core Android experience—software engineers who have written code below the application level. Java developers and Android developers are totally fine.

Q You are originally from Android, but you chose to do something that is not open source, but closed-source. Any reasons for this choice?

This is something the company has thought about a lot. Managing an open source project is a very different thing, from what we do today. So we thought that what we would rather do is contribute back. So, while our core UI is not open, we actually contribute a lot back, not only to Android, but to other initiatives as well. HBASE is one database initiative for which our team is the No. 1 contributor.

Q What are your thoughts on the Android One platform?

I think it's a phenomenal effort from Google. It's a very clever program. It is designed to empower members of the ecosystem, who you might label as challengers, and to help them reap real incentives. So I think it is a very, very cleverly designed program. I am very excited to see it taking off in India.

Q Is it true that Xiaomi provides weekly updates for its devices?

We provide weekly updates for our Mi device family. We have two families—the Redmi family and the Mi family. We provide weekly updates for the devices of the Mi family on what we call the beta channel. So when you buy a Mi 3, for example, it's on what we call the stable

channel, which gets updates every one or two months. But if you want to be on the beta channel and get updates every week, to be the one to try out features first, all you have to do is go to the MIUI forum and download the beta channel ROM to flash it to your device. It is a very simple thing to do, and then you are on the beta channel and will get weekly updates.

Q So what is the idea behind such weekly updates? Are they not too frequent for even power users to adopt?

The power users take them all the time. Their take rate is incredibly high. These are people who have chosen to take these over-the-air updates. They have actively said: "I want to be on the beta channel because I want weekly updates." And the reason they do it is because they want to get access to features early, they want to provide feedback, they like having the latest and greatest software on their devices. They want to participate and that is why people want to join in.

Q Google promotes stock Android usage. You also did the same when you were with Google, so forking Android is not happily accepted by Google. Given that, where do you see Android reaching eventually in this game?

From Google's perspective and from my perspective as well, the most important thing in the Android ecosystem is for the devices to remain compatible. To me, the two most important things are: first, every Android device must be 100 per cent compatible, and second, all of Google's innovations must reach every Android user. In the approach that we have taken as an OS developer, we are checking both these boxes one hundred per cent.

Our devices, even those selling in China, without any of Google's apps, are 100 per cent compatible and have always been so, which means that all of the Android APIs work perfectly. They pass all the compatibility apps, which means that you will never have apps crashing. Second, because we are pre-loading all of Google's apps (outside of China of course, where we are allowed to preload Google's apps), we are enabling all of the innovation that Google has to reach every MIUI user. So we are checking all the boxes.

I think you need to be careful when using the word 'forking' because you may be confusing yourself and your users with forks that are not compatible—forks that break away from the Android ecosystem, if you will. I'm not going to mention names but that is unhealthy for the ecosystem. That is almost a sin, because it is going to lead to user frustration at some point, sooner or later. Apps are going to start crashing or not working. That is a bad thing to do. It's just not a good idea and obviously we will not do that. We are 100 per cent Android compatible, we are 100 per cent behind Android, and we love what the Android teams do. 